

The Paradox of Representation:
Exploring the Tension between Empowerment
and Idolisation in Women's Fitness Content on TikTok.

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Abstract

In my study I examine the tension between empowerment and idolisation in women's fitness content on TikTok. Using a mixed-method approach of an ethnographic observation and semiotic analysis, the research explores how visual elements and TikTok's algorithm influence fitness narratives. Findings revealed how although TikTok may support diverse representations of women and promote body neutrality, the algorithmic platform can maintain traditional beauty standards. As a result, TikTok redefines women's relationships with fitness and body image while exposing the limits of gender empowerment on social media platforms. According to the study's findings, awareness of how algorithms affect and alter appearance-focused information is important for generational change. In order to understand how digital platforms impact our identities in complicated and empowering ways, my research study explores the convergence of body image, digital culture, and algorithmic influence.

Introduction

'Health' no longer holds a singular, definitive meaning in modern-day society. The World Health Organisation defines health as 'a state of complete physical, mental and social well-being and not merely the absence of disease or infirmity' (World Health Organization, no date). As social media has grown and technology has advanced, the idea of health has evolved into a flexible concept. Being 'healthy' might mean different things to different people, depending on their own values, aspirations, and situations.

Cultural shifts and the rise of social media platforms have changed how women are being represented. Traditional media once relied on selling unrealistic representations of women to market products and reinforce unattainable beauty standards (Pounders, 2018). However, in contemporary society, this approach may not work anymore as a response to changing cultural perceptions and evolving societal values. Despite these transformations, I continue to observe pre-existing pressures in the online realm of idealistic health and beauty standards.

Among the digital platforms entwined in people's lives, TikTok has become one of the largest and most used applications worldwide. According to recent 2025 statistics, TikTok has approximately 955.3 million active users; compared to 2020, it recorded 465.7 million (Ceci, 2024). With its algorithm-driven system and participatory culture, TikTok has grown to provide a space where diverse representations of women can be curated, shared and consumed.

In particular, online fitness communities and women's fitness content has grown in popularity (Stollfuß, 2020; Wang et al., 2024), with creators sharing their content to encourage 'healthy' lifestyles and empower others. Videos may include meal planning, daily exercise routines, and transformation stories. Women have become increasingly aware of public expectations placed upon them and, as a result, use social media to change oppressive narratives. Fitness-related TikTok content has mirrored this shift to become a more positive and inclusive platform. I have observed, nevertheless, the fundamental conflicts between idolisation and empowerment. Fitness TikTok's have complex underlying narratives, thereby this study is crucial for understanding how the gender representation behaves in these new digital dynamics.

Existing research has studied various topics related to the connections between social media platforms and body image. Themes such as body neutrality, authenticity, social comparison, and digital intimacies have been thoroughly researched.

For instance, Seekis and Lawrence (2023) explored the connections between how body-neutral content on TikTok can affect a woman's body image. Their findings found that when women were exposed to body-neutral content, they 'reported higher levels of joyous moods and fewer upward appearance comparisons' (Seekis and Lawrence, 2023, p.6). They focused on women's appreciation for body functionality; this unique insight revealed important academic knowledge. They concluded their study by stating that these shifts within social media can 'help curb the pressure to meet unrealistic

beauty standards' (Seekis and Lawrence, 2023, p.7). However, a limitation would be their use of curated TikTok compilations in their methodology. This restricts the studies insights into TikTok's algorithmic influences, that have an important role of influencing user experience and, thus, user perceptions.

Reade (2020) investigated another significant area of social media, examining authenticity and digital intimacies on Instagram. Her study demonstrated how posting unedited images can encourage a sense of belonging and challenge traditional body ideals. She references a popular social media term, 'keeping it raw,' which describes when people share 'realistic' visuals of the body... and talk about struggles with mental health and body image' (Reade, 2020, p.536). Using a feminist new materialist approach, Reade analyses how body parts and discourses interact to embody this notion of 'raw'. Her thematic analysis revealed how authenticity on social media fosters a sense of belonging and acceptance among users. Reade concludes that 'posting the body raw provides a 'photographic truth' (2020, p.544), suggesting that women who post consciously and challenge traditional body image ideals can cultivate community and contribute to societal change. However, the exclusive focus on Instagram overlooks other platforms, such as TikTok, where fitness content is equally prevalent.

Similarly, Toffoletti et al. (2023) examined performative practices and mutual Vulnerability. This study highlighted how Instagram can promote shared encouragement and create a supportive community where women can offer each other emotional support. The study drew on Judith Butler's theories of 'shared vulnerability and interdependency' (Toffoletti et al., 2023, p.5), adopting a feminist relational approach. The qualitative research established that Instagram has become a space for self-presentation and a place where communities have been formed. A limitation of this study is the demographic selection, which were fitness enthusiasts. Narrowing the focus limits the diversity of perspectives and could generalise the findings.

Lastly, research into social comparison and self-objectification has been critically assessed. Several studies have underlined how social media can present traditional beauty ideals and induce social comparison. Lewallen and Behm-Morawitz (2016) and Chen et al. (2023) discussed how social media could increase appearance anxiety, where women may change their behaviour due to online content, such as exercising or how they edit their photos. Both studies mention how women experience feelings of need for approval and inadequacy as they are consistently exposed to content they need to aspire to.

Despite these studies' important insights, gaps remain. As presented, Instagram has been predominantly reviewed, whereas TikTok has become a rising platform for sharing fitness, well-being and body image content. While there has also been an evident shift in body inclusivity and positive digital intimacies, there has been limited exploration of how this type of content may have underlying complexities. The concern of how idolisation and empowerment are both being curated in social media platforms is a new area to be explored. Therefore, with a limited understanding of TikTok's algorithmic structure, my study addresses this by investigating how women's fitness content presents a dual narrative of empowerment and idolisation. I focus on the platform's algorithmic influence and how different semiotic elements embedded in the content may change a viewer's understanding. By

exploring the intersection of body image, algorithmic content, and performativity, this research study aims to uncover whether TikTok can support positive cultural change or maintain existing pressures of idealised bodies and unattainable lifestyles.

Theoretical framework

This chapter presents the theoretical framework supporting this study's examination of fitness content on TikTok. Informed by Feminist Media Studies, Objectification theory and an understanding of TikTok's algorithmic structure, this chapter critically interrogates TikTok's dual role as a platform embedding empowerment and pre-existing societal pressures. I will establish a foundation for analysing the relationships between digital media, gendered representation and broader cultural narratives defining women's identities and fitness engagements.

Feminist Media Studies and the Representation of the Female Body

Critiquing Gendered Representations: Feminist Media Studies in the contemporary media

Feminist media studies provide a critical foundation for my research, proposing important ways to assess how the media represents gender stereotypes and power dynamics. Central to the field of study, my studies analysis of how women's bodies and identities are portrayed in social media reflects the broader cultural and institutional practices. Zoonen's (1994) *Feminist Media Studies* text presents several important points for my study. She underlines how feminist studies have emerged from the 'Marxist theory and left politics' (Zoonen, 1994, p.6) to develop a cultural critique where cultural norms have sustained patriarchal structures. It is important for research to examine the shifting cultural dynamics around gender portrayal to understand how authority persists in differing media platforms. It is critical to recognise the ways in which patriarchal stereotypes reinforced by the media can affect a woman's identity and sense of self.

Building on this understanding, Feminist Media Studies critically observe how gender representations in media not only reflect but actively shape societal constructs. A significant principle is the analysis of how women are stereotypically presented to 'transmit sexist, patriarchal, or capitalist values to contribute to the maintenance of social order' (Zoonen, 1994, p. 27). Through questioning these portrayals, feminist scholars reveal how the media's role acts as a cultural force by either reinforcing or challenging representations of women.

This critique has evolved in present Feminist Media Studies, which now emphasise the construction of the female body as a site of cultural fixation (Zoonen, 1994). As reinforced by Harvey (2020, p.62), women have consistently been underrepresented and placed in 'delimited roles across the media landscape'. The concern is how this has not changed; the media still portrays idealised standards of beauty, reinforcing unattainable ideals of women. These representations are deeply embedded within social and political ideologies. As Zoonen (1994, p.30) argues, feminist media studies advocate for 'more realistic images of women and definitions of femininity,' challenging the cultural forces that may influence a woman's self-perception and identity.

The critical principle aligned with this study is understanding how audiences interpret and respond to media portrayals of gender. Feminist media studies emphasise the active role of viewers, particularly women, in resisting or subverting media messages (Zoonen, 1994). Audiences critique

gender stereotypes by subverting traditional media narratives, escaping the role of being passive consumers. Zoonen (1994) conceptualises gender as a discourse, emphasising that repeated cultural representations shape understandings of sexual differences. Gender representations have become more varied and diverse as social media has revolutionised how gender is constructed. Through discussion, the production of alternative media, and the rewriting of current narratives, the public can now question cultural norms. This understanding connects to the principle that Feminist Media Studies highlight spaces where women and marginalised communities produce content that challenges traditional constructions of gender. For example, social media content adopts a broader spectrum of identities, countering the homogenised ideals perpetuated by mainstream and traditional media. Where user-generated content is significant in platforms like TikTok, the relationship between dominant and alternative representations can influence cultural understanding of gender and identity.

Applying the Male Gaze: Objectification and Empowerment in Women's Fitness Content

Furthermore, Laura Mulvey's Male Gaze theory, first introduced in her 1975 essay 'Visual Pleasure and the Narrative Cinema' (Hein, 2008, p.3), is fundamental to my study's framework. Mulvey conveys how mainstream cinema represents women as objects for the satisfaction of male spectators. Males are positioned as active, whilst females are passive (Hein, 2008, p.4). She proposes that women are constructed in the media to be displayed as 'fetishistic' ideals for male viewers, reinforcing the idea that a woman's value depends on their physical and sexual appearance. Mulvey's understanding aligns with Feminist Media critiques of how language and representations used within cinema are 'shaped by dominant social relations' (Harvey, 2020, p.69). Media outputs reflect patriarchal sexual desires and, as a result, objectify women.

The application of Mulvey's theory to women's online fitness content can analyse how women's bodies are being presented to challenge or conform to traditional stereotypes or expectations. With a focus on women's fitness content, female creators construct and post content they desire to share. Although fitness content can support females and share positive messages to disrupt patriarchal norms, it is possible that creators and viewers could internalise this content and self-objectify. Fitness content may continue to pressure women to achieve idealised standards of beauty and affect their body image and self-worth.

Vulnerability and Empowerment: The Dual Role of Online Fitness Content

Judith Butler's (2014) book *Rethinking Vulnerability and Resistance* provides a crucial framework for my study. Butler proposes that 'gender performativity does not just characterise what we do, but how discourse and institutional power affect us' (Butler, 2014, p.8), proposing gender is constructed through repeated social performances. For my studies focus, performativity can be examined in terms of how women's bodies are represented and shared among online platforms. Investigating whether societal pressures are still reflected in new media.

Butler further extends this by explaining how 'vulnerability is not a subjective disposition, but a relation to a field of objects, forces, and passions that impinge upon or affect us in some way' (2014, p.16). Through this, Butler (2014) implies that vulnerability can emerge because of movements and democracy. This idea is supported in her *Gender Troubles* text (Butler, 1990), where she highlights how subversion and resistance through non-conforming acts can challenge power structures.

These ideas of movements can be analysed in contemporary social media, where people have the ability to share their messages and desired representations. The process of individuals choosing to post online content can present this idea of gender performance through their content. Women present their bodies online, potentially aligning or subverting to societal norms. It should be considered how even though the fitness content has progressed, women may have become exposed to more vulnerable content. Movements to empower bodies and post-body-neutral content can still highlight an viewers idea of vulnerability.

Through incorporating relevant findings from feminist media studies and these theorists, my framework investigates the broader understanding of how fitness content is produced and consumed . Whilst current fitness content arguably displays women contributing to the subversion of traditional stereotypes and a positive shift in the framing of female bodies, it is necessary to assess how the increased representation of body types may reinforce the importance of physical appearance and continue the objectification of the female body. Through performative acts in social media, content may seem progressive, but the showcase of bodies performing specific fitness and health ideals conforms to placing societal pressure on women. When assessing the visual elements of social media, such as camera angles and editing techniques, these can contribute to the objectification or the contrasting empowerment of women. Consequently, body-positive content can create a new set of pressures and reinforce how a woman's worth is tied to their body and their ability to perform specific ideals of femininity in fitness and health.

Body Image, Self-Objectification, and the Individualisation of Experience

The Digital Gaze: How TikTok Amplifies Self-Objectification

Theories and knowledge surrounding body image and self-objectification highlight key concepts for my framework. Developed by Fredrickson and Roberts (1997, p.175), they state objectification is when women are viewed as bodies that exist for the use and pleasure of others. They expand on this by introducing the idea of how women may internalise the perspective of an observer. This internalised perspective focuses on appearance rather than performance.

In relation to this, Featherstone (2010) develops on the understanding body image and consumer culture. He states how 'the cultivation of appearance has a strong gender dimension, with greater scrutiny given to women's bodies' (2010, p.202). He emphasises that even though modern

society is beginning to circulate broader images of women, there are still underlying gender differentials (Featherstone, 2010,p.202).

From this understanding of body image and objectification, the presentation of women's bodies in fitness content could lead to self-objectification. Social media content may lead viewers to internalise the differing messages presented, resulting in feelings of shame and comparison.

The Paradox of Empowerment: Individualised Body Image Concerns in Inclusive Content

Present fitness and well-being content promotes many ideas related to self-love and empowerment. However, it can mistakably lead to the individualisation of body image concerns. Women posting body-neutral TikTok content emphasising messages of self-love can instead enhance the idealisation of certain body types or promote self-worth through appearance. This is consistent with the objectification theory of Fredrickson and Roberts (1997), which holds that internalised viewpoints lead women to judge themselves more on the basis of their looks than their skills or accomplishments.

This concept of an individualistic approach can obscure the societal and cultural influences contributing to body image concerns. Featherstone's (2010) insight regarding the enduring nature of gendered scrutiny is relevant in this context because the framework that paradoxically encourages women to love themselves continuously maintains idealised ideals of beauty and appearance. Fitness content focusing on self-empowerment can negatively impact women already struggling with body image and feeling emotions of failure. Empowering fitness and well-being content could imply how overcoming body dissatisfaction is simple and a matter of self-determination rather than a response to global, external pressures. Through this examination of personal responsibility, body image concerns risk disregarding the more significant social and cultural factors.

My study can draw significant relations for the theoretical framework by analysing body Image, Objectification, and the Individualisation of Experience. Examining this regarding fitness content can emphasise how an individual's journey of self-love and acceptance can be contrasted to reinforce ideas of how body image is solely an individual's responsibility. Equally, rather than feeling empowered, women may compare their bodies to a wider spectrum of idealised body types as a result of the increased representation of varied body types in fitness content.

Social Media, Algorithmic Culture, and the Construction of Meaning

Algorithmic influence: TikTok's role in shaping fitness perceptions

Current social media platforms are highly influential in determining how users perceive and engage globally. TikTok is one of the newest applications, launching only in 2017 (Schellewald, 2023, p.1568), and has become one of the most used social media apps worldwide. Statistics show TikTok has been downloaded 4.92 billion times (Shepherd, 2024). TikTok's global demographics and exponential growth have played a crucial role in how creators communicate meaning. As social media

has developed, there is an increased accessibility for users to produce and share their own content. The phrase 'content producers', which refers to social media users who use global platforms to engage in media entrepreneurship and develop personal brands, has gained broad popularity (Craig, 2020, p. 363). Social media has become a platform for both individual expression and cultural influence as a result of this growth, which has allowed ordinary individuals to reach a large audience and share their ideas.

As TikTok has become a well-known space for content creators, there has been a notable increase in fitness-related content. Statistics show that videos using '#health' have accumulated over 85.6 billion views, emphasising how popular health and exercise topics have become (Haddock, 2023). Women, in particular, have begun using the platform to share their fitness and health content, sharing a variety of messages. Their content may promote a more inclusive and positive environment to help improve ideas of body image and relationships with food and diet. In current academia, TikTok has yet to be explored as much as other online platforms. TikTok plays an important part in customising the way that people consume fitness content. To understand how social media platforms impact cultural changes, it is crucial to research TikTok.

Filter Bubbles and 'Universal Sameness': TikTok's Algorithmic Culture

TikTok's algorithmic structure is carefully crafted to enhance user experience. TikTok relies on 'various user activities, including browsing, liking, comment-ing and retweeting, to evaluate user preferences' (Chen, 2023, p.2). Algorithms will utilise user behaviour and preferences to filter information from this data. Users may now easily consume large amounts of content due to the platform's rapid turnover and the ability to scan videos in short periods. However, a significant criticism of social media algorithms is how they enhance content that generates engagement through emotional or outrage appeal (Walsh, 2020). Users on TikTok are consistently exposed to content that aligns with their prior beliefs or interests. Driven feeds use algorithms that analyse behavioural tracking to personalise content recommendations.

TikTok's algorithmic structure could create a filter bubble effect. The filter bubble effect, described by Pariser (2011), has three central dynamics: how you are alone, it is invisible, and you do not choose to be in it. Within the present online community, many users are entwined in their bubbles as they are continuously exposed to specific messages and ideals through personalised content exposed to them. A key concern about filter bubbles raised by Pariser is that 'there is less room for the chance of encounters that bring insight and learning.' (2011, p.15). Thus, as individuals become entangled in their bubbles, present society may need more creativity and the creation of mixed diverse disciplines. Research conducted by Scalvini (2023) further analysed this concern, presenting the idea of how TikTok's algorithmic structure can promote the apparent perception of diverse content whilst adhering to a 'universal sameness' (p.2). The study's findings highlight the inconsistency TikTok creates; whilst it provides entertainment and gratification for users, it also has several ethical problems. TikTok's

algorithmic structure can enhance and continue to create filter bubbles that expose users to specific messages and promote the idea of 'universal sameness'.

Regarding body image and women's health, these ideas of filter bubbles are an increased concern within women's fitness content. Pariser emphasises that 'the filter bubble can affect your ability to choose how you want to live' (2011, p.16). In examining this concept through women's online fitness content, ideals presented to women on TikTok about health, body image, and well-being can forever change how someone lives. Whether it is a positive or an adverse change in an individual life, the impact social media withholds on how someone lives is being amplified through TikTok's structure. Users may become over-exposed to these trends and multiple messages that create societal pressure about navigating their health and well-being. Therefore, risks of the algorithmic curation of TikTok can limit exposure to diverse perspectives, contributing to the repetition of social norms and values that women depict from content.

This chapter has established the theoretical framework that has critically integrated Feminist Media Studies, objectification and body image concepts, and understanding TikTok's algorithmic culture. My framework has presented how fitness content can simultaneously challenge and reinforce traditional ideals of femineity. The next chapter will detail the research methodology used in this study to investigate these intersections within TikTok fitness content. Through the application of this framework in my methodology, I can contribute valuable insights into the evolving role of digital platforms in changing cultural discourses and gender representations.

Methodology

This chapter outlines the methodological framework for investigating how TikTok fitness content is structured and how opposing narratives can influence a woman's self-perceptions of their body, health and fitness behaviours. This study employs an interpretive and qualitative approach through ethnographic observation and semiotic analysis. I immersed myself in TikTok to create an ethnographic diary of related content to women's fitness and well-being, followed by a semiotic analysis to closely analyse the videos visual, textual and performative elements. The following research questions guided this methodology:

Research Question 1: What patterns and elements in women's fitness content on TikTok contribute to inclusivity and empowerment, and how are these messages translated across the platform?

Research Question 2: How does fitness content and the creators choices contribute to idolisation of physical appearance, even while promoting new ideas of femininity?

Research Question 3: How does TikTok's algorithmic structure influence the consumption and perception of fitness content?

Methods and Justification

This study explored the topic through a qualitative ethnographic diary and semiotic analysis. A qualitative research design for this study was required because it 'provides further insights into real-world problems' (Tenny, Brannan and Brannan, 2022). By focusing on TikTok content presenting women's fitness, my study examined how female creators position themselves and present narratives of exercise and health. Interpreting meaning from TikTok videos was not linear because attitude, behaviour and experiences can be challenging to quantify. Through the deconstruction of TikTok content, patterns and elements were identified to understand the meaning and cultural connotations, understanding its role in changing social understanding.

This interpretative approach for the study was significant in analysing the influence of TikTok and how meanings are embedded. As stated by Harvey (2020, p.33) the 'interpretive approaches enable a consideration of the media, and those who engage with it in their social, cultural and historical contexts, which is well suited to a critical feminist politics'. By immersing myself in TikTok as an ethnographic observer, the interpretive paradigm considers the researcher's role in interpreting data and how biases can influence the research process. It was also relevant for capturing the context-specific interpretations of visual, textual and performative elements, which a positivist framework would not do due to its focus on objectivity and hypothesis testing. The exploratory methods of ethnographic observation and a semiotic analysis supported an inductive approach as the research processed and

analysed data to generate categories from female fitness content. The research aimed to explore TikTok content without preconceived hypotheses, allowing findings to emerge naturally.

The data collection began with an ethnographic observation of TikTok videos, systematically conducted and documented in a diary each evening from November 4th to November 10th, 2024. TikTok videos about health, exercise, diets, and body image were observed and documented in a digital diary. Visual ethnography explored by Pink (2013, p.1) justifies how images can 'inhabit and inspire our imaginations, technologies, texts and conversations'. Methods of ethnography have evolved as technology has become more advanced. Pink (2013,p.124) highlighted how technology has changed ethnographic techniques, recommending that academics employ digital platforms to document modern cultural activities.

Thereby, observations for this study were made for 20 minutes daily, providing insights into the platform's algorithmic patterns and the narratives shared by content creators. The diary's reflective notes conveyed the interplay between empowerment and societal pressures, along with emerging patterns of inclusivity, body positivity and the influence of algorithm-driven personalisation.

Following on, I then analysed the semiotics of eleven videos from the diary. As Curtis and Curtis (2011, p.4) defined, 'semiotic analysis is the study of signs and their meaning relating to the social world and social processes'. The analysis aimed to decode elements in TikTok content to reveal underlying beliefs, values, and ideologies. Aligning with Roland Barthes's theory of semiotics, the study employed a denotation and connotation approach to identify signifiers and their meaning.

Bouzida (2014, p.1001) emphasises how Barthes' describes denotation as concrete while connotation is more complex and abstract'. His understanding of how the two layers of an image consist of what it is and how it is represented is a key concept that frames my data analysis. It was important to employ a semiotic analysis because it supported the findings from the ethnographic diary, dissecting the different elements and algorithmic influence. Semiotics aligned well with analysing TikTok videos because ideas of body image, health, and fitness can be shown through textual, visual, and performative elements.

Data Analysis

Data analysis for this study included transcribing textual elements, such as subtitles and captions and coding visual and performative elements to identify recurring patterns. Transcripts of TikTok content identified key vocabulary and messaging used by creators to be analysed to determine how women position ideals of related fitness and health themes. Screenshots and video segments were saved to highlight key parts of the TikTok videos.

In the semiotic analysis, the videos were categorised into three dimensions aligning with the theoretical framework and research questions: 1) The complexity of female representation, (2) The Individualisation of Body Image, and (3) The Algorithmic Gaze. Eleven TikTok videos were chosen, and these three dimensions were then analysed to learn more about the connections between the initial diary observations and semiotics.

Throughout the study, reflexive techniques were used to reduce subjectivity and potential biases, confirming the validity and comprehensiveness of the results. For this research, I was aware of mine own positionality, biases and assumptions that could influence data interpretation.

Sampling

TikTok was chosen as the platform for this research due to its relevance in shaping fitness culture and its significant influence on women. Purposeful sampling was used each evening to select the TikTok videos that were rich in information relevant to the research questions (Emmel, 2013). The 'For you page' was how videos were selected, providing a more randomised selection and linking to my third research question about TikTok's algorithm. Improving on Seekis and Lawrence (2023) study that yielded exploration into TikTok's algorithm by using curated compilations.

Data saturation was achieved through the selected sample size, and additional videos would unlikely yield new themes or insights. Videos were saved to ensure data availability even if the original content was removed.

Operationalisation

This study operationalised key theoretical frameworks to investigate the dynamics of women's fitness content on TikTok. Laura Mulvey's male gaze theory (Hein, 2008), and concepts of objectification and body image (Fredrickson and Roberts, 1997; Featherstone, 2010), were used in the study to examine whether fitness content reinforces or subverts representations where women may be viewed as visual objects for public consumption. Butler's (2014) theory of performativity was employed to evaluate how women might perform particular fitness or health ideals that align with societal expectations or contrastingly challenge them. Lastly, the filter bubble (Pariser, 2011), and 'universal sameness' (Scalvini, 2023) concept considers how TikTok's algorithmic structure personalises a user's experience and may emphasise specific body ideals and trends, possibly intensifying or isolating particular fitness ideals.

Criteria for categorisation

The research analysed TikTok videos , categorising and evaluating content based on semiotic elements including visual, textual, and performative.

Visual elements: This will include body types represented, camera angles, editing styles, lighting, clothing, and accessory choices. These elements will be examined for their roles in creating societal ideals related to fitness and well-being.

Textual elements: Language in subtitles, voiceovers and layered text will be evaluated for messages evolving around body image, health, and empowerment. Keywords will be identified to identify potential patterns in messaging.

Performative elements: Body language, facial expressions, interactions with the camera, and ways of self-representation will be assessed to see if they align with or resist traditional expectations. This includes noting if the content encourages self-objectification or reflects more genuine, inclusive self-representations.

Validity and Reliability

Validity within qualitative research defines the 'appropriateness' of the tools, processes, and data' (Leung, 2015, p.325). To ensure this study was valid, the research design and methodologies aligned with the set research questions to avoid external interpretations. The study process was promptly recorded through a clear and thorough ethnographic diary.

Reliability in qualitative research is more challenging because of the diverse paradigm. Thus, the way to maintain reliability in qualitative research is to be constant, as Leung (2015) highlighted. Reproducible data gathering was made possible by the ethnographic diary's clear and organised documentation of observations and conclusions.

By examining a wide variety of TikTok videos, triangulation was accomplished, enabling deeper understanding of concepts and trends in women's fitness content. These methods made sure the study's conclusions were reliable and credible..

Ethical Considerations

Remaining ethical is a fundamental part of any research. For this study, the only considerations were using publicly available content and minimising algorithmic influences by monitoring browsing behaviour during data collection. Each TikTok video selected and saved was available to the public.

Research Limitations

Very few limitations might have influenced the results of this study. Its exclusive concentration on TikTok is an important disadvantage, as it restricts the applicability of the results to other platforms. The content seen may have been modified by the TikTok algorithm's built-in customisation of content according on user interactions, even with efforts to reduce algorithmic influences. Lastly, semiotic analysis is primarily interpretative; whilst reflexivity was employed, the researcher's perspectives and experience could have subconsciously influenced the decoding of video elements.

This chapter outlined the methodological approach used to examine the complexities of narratives in women's fitness content on TikTok. The research intends to interpret meanings embedded in fitness content through a qualitative design combining ethnographic observation and semiotic analysis. The following chapter presents the findings and discusses how fitness content continues to share complex and dual messages around body positivity and empowerment.

Data Analysis and Discussion

This chapter analyses and discusses findings from the ethnographic diary and semiotic analysis. For the semiotic analysis of the TikTok videos, they have been categorised into three dimensions that align with the research questions. (1) The complexity of female representation, (2) The Individualisation of Body Image, and (3) The Algorithmic Gaze. The videos' visual, textual and performative elements have been examined to deconstruct how messages about women's bodies, health and fitness are conveyed. The following three sections explore the connections between the mixed research methods, showcasing whether the semiotics presented in the content either support or subvert the initial ethnographic observations. Each dimension will uncover how patterns in fitness content create a dual narrative between empowerment and idolisation and how this may influence a woman's self-perceptions and fitness behaviours. (See Appendix A1 for the ethnographic diary)

Dimension 1: Empowerment or Objectification? The complex messaging of women's fitness Representation

This first dimension explores how fitness content can both empower and objectify women. This complexity is evident through the representation of idealistic body types, fitness lifestyles and transformation narratives.

First, the ethnographic diary provided critical insights into the occurrence of mixed-message narratives. During the observation period, content promoting transformation journeys and disciplined fitness routines repeatedly appeared, each promoting messages of self-improvement. Creators used captions like 'Make it happen, girl' and 'Every rep and drop of sweat build the life you want.' (See Appendix A for full ethnographic details), which reinforced a correlation between achieving physical goals and personal success.

Building on these observations, the semiotic analysis revealed further insights into how underlying patterns and elements in TikTok can enhance the complex, dual narrative. Four videos, in particular, amplified the tension between empowerment and objectification (For the semiotic analysis of the TikTok's, see Appendix B, Tables 1,2,3 and 4). Every video focused on the body, frequently using long views and close-ups to draw the viewer's attention to the physical attributes. Furthermore, one notable trend in the observation was body transformation TikTok's. Creators shared their fitness journeys that solely focused on how their physical appearance had changed. As exemplified in Figure 1, the user has begun the video with her performing an exercise in the gym with a bold caption in the centre of the frame titled 'don't you dare give up', followed up soon after with a shot of her posing towards the camera, see figure 2. Towards the end of the video she appears more confident based on

the shift in her body language. This shares a message to viewers that being happier or more successful is linked to having a smaller body.

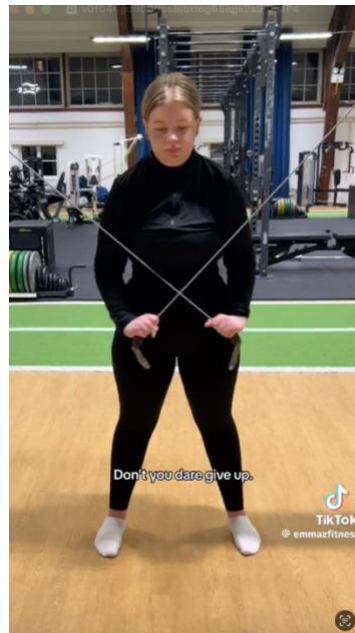


Figure 1– TikTok Screenshot from Appendix B, Table 2



Figure 2 – TikTok Screenshot from Appendix B, Table 2

Furthermore, the four videos included captions, voiceovers or music to enhance their motivational messages and inspire their viewers. However, captions such as 'You got three months left', as seen in Figure 3, could potentially harm viewers. Although the videos aim to encourage viewers to exercise, this type of phrasing could make viewers feel guilty or pressured to attain a socially and culturally accepted appearance. Thereby reinforcing the harmful narrative that achievement is aligned with self-worth and aesthetics.

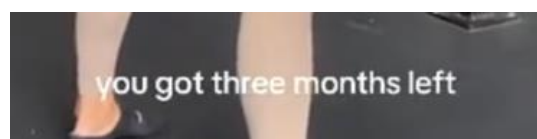


Figure 3 – TikTok Screenshot from Appendix B, Table 1

Finally, similar visual components, such as studio/professional lighting and typical gym attire and settings, were utilised in every TikTok. These videos created a polished, effortless atmosphere that enhanced the body's appearance and glorified the 'fit' aesthetic. Although these videos are conventionally visually appealing, the creators' intended efforts to share fitness content and motivate others may be subverted as they conform to unrealistic standards of beauty and fitness ideals. Instead of undermining social forces, this conformity runs the risk of creating them. The loop of aesthetic validation may be intensified by this content, which makes it difficult for viewers to distinguish between sharing unachievable aspirations and empowering content.

Therefore, the alignment between the ethnographic diary and semiotic analysis supports the complexity of the representation of women in fitness content. My analysis confirms that existing societal pressures are still present in social media content. Evidently creators are aiming to empower viewers, but their underlying messages reflect pre-existing cycles of objectification, aesthetic validation, and constrained empowerment. Through this mixed messaging, TikTok has become a platform where gender representations are being both challenged and maintained, complicating the viewers' perceptions of their fitness, identity, and self-worth.

Dimension 2: The performance of 'self-love' narratives and contradictions in Individualised body image messaging

The next dimension analysed is the performance of self-love narratives, exploring how even though the content challenges the pressures women face, it could inadvertently individualise body image concerns.

During the ethnographic observation period, TikTok's algorithm frequently presented content emphasising body positivity and self-acceptance. Videos featuring unfiltered bodies captioned around self-love were notably repeated in the diary entries. These observations showcased a shift towards authenticity as creators embraced a rawer representation of themselves.

The following semiotic analysis reinforced and expanded on the diary's insights (See Appendix B, Tables 5,6,7,8 for each video's semiotic analysis). Unlike the previous section, where visual elements idolised the creators, this dimension included visuals that connote a more authentic representation of the female body. Natural lighting, everyday environments, and minimal editing created imagery of a 'normal' individual. Through the subversion of polished and unattainable representations of women, the content appears more relatable, which could improve the trust and relationship with the viewer. For example, in Figure 4, the creator shares an impactful message by running a marathon in her underwear. The video's unedited shots, natural lighting and simple transitions collectively reinforce the message of body acceptance and rejection of idealised 'fit' bodies.



Figure 4 – TikTok Screenshot from Appendix B, Table 5

Additionally, performative elements of smiling, dancing and joyful movements were key semiotics that connote positive and self-acceptance body language. These camera shots were an important non-verbal cue that signified comfort in the bodies they wanted to celebrate. Direct interactions were used in each of the videos to emphasise a sense of intimacy and shared experiences with the viewers. This could encourage an empowering community of self-acceptance among TikTok. Lastly, all the videos used layered captions to embed their messages. For example, see Figure 5. The caption was 'no restriction, what I eat in a day ', challenging the toxic trends of restrictive diet cultures.



Figure 5 - TikTok Screenshot from Appendix B, Table 8

Overall, these videos emphasised personal self-acceptance that goes beyond society's expectations of perfection. Nevertheless, it is important to think about how creators could individualise body image issues for viewers even though they actively oppose social constraints placed on women. These videos often focus on individual effort and mindset, portraying self-acceptance as a personal achievement. Whereas pressures are placed on women from more significant systemic issues, creators are placing a burden of body image and self-acceptance on the individual instead of critiquing societal pressures.

Dimension 3: The Algorithmic Gaze - Shaping Fitness Narratives on TikTok

This final semiotic analysis establishes how TikTok's algorithmic structure can prioritise specific types of content, changing what messages and visuals the users encounter.

Within the ethnographic observation period, TikTok consistently displayed content that was aligned with previously viewed videos. This diary demonstrated the platform's utilisation of algorithm-driven recommendations. The rotation of familiar content is demonstrated by the frequent repapering of videos with inspirational captions like 'Every choice matters' and 'Be consistent, results will come', with similar creators and topics. This pattern demonstrates how TikTok's algorithm restricts the range of perspectives that viewers can see while personalising the user experience.

Elaborating on these preliminary results, a number of recurring semiotic features in the TikTok videos were presented that may related to the algorithmic intelligence of TikTok. Content often featured a direct mode of address, to emphasise their messages and engage their viewers. Direct eye contact, seen in Figure 6, enhances the personal connection with the audience and supports the understanding of the algorithmic gaze, where creators will tailor their content to attract and retain viewers. Videos often used layered text and subtitles, as presented in the previous two dimensions. Captions act as -



Figure 6 - TikTok Screenshot from Appendix B, Table 6

visual signifiers that show the video's narrative and can help algorithms identify relevant content, increasing discoverability and engagement. (See Appendix B, Tables 9,10 and 11 for the complete semiotic analysis)

Furthermore, as observed in the ethnographic diary, there were also various messages about fitness and lifestyles. The conventional gym environment and outfit in Figure 7 enhance the user sharing her fitness routine, whereas Figure 8 uses a simple frame of herself in the car whilst talking through the societal standards social media places on women. These differing TikTok's showcase two completely different narratives through opposite semiotic elements. When analysing the ethnographic diary, content that included fitness routines, idealistic body types, and focus on aesthetic validation appeared more often than progressive messages. This demonstrates how TikTok's algorithmic structure may be filtering out certain types of content depending on their focus.

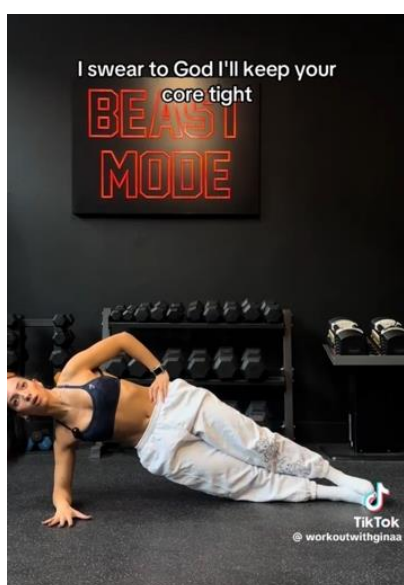


Figure 7- TikTok Screenshot from Appendix B, Table 9 Figure 8- TikTok Screenshot from Appendix B, Table 10

Together, the results of the semiotic analysis and ethnographic journal demonstrate the function of TikTok's algorithmic framework. TikTok ensures that content seems relevant and interesting by personalising the user experience. TikTok's algorithmic platform promotes a curated sameness that can limit the diversity of content. This could risk continued cultural pressures around body image and fitness because creators contribute to the cycle of constrained empowerment, where individuality is celebrated within the boundaries of culturally approved norms.

Discussion

Overall, the combined findings from the ethnographic diary and semiotic analysis present the influential role of TikTok's algorithmic structure. Through the personalisation of users experiences, the platform is consistently ensuring viewers consume relevant and engaging videos. This could risk

continued cultural pressures around body image and idolised fitness ideals because creators contribute to the cycle of constrained empowerment, where individuality is celebrated within the boundaries of culturally approved norms.

Research Question 1: What patterns and elements in women's fitness content on TikTok contribute to inclusivity and empowerment, and how are these messages translated across the platform?

The findings reveal notable patterns and elements in women's fitness content contributing to inclusivity and empowerment. Many creators shared messages of body neutrality, self-love and empowerment, challenging traditional beauty standards through diverse representations of body types and fitness journeys.

For example, the content in dimension two, with minimal editing and natural lighting, conveys relatability and authenticity, aligning with Butler's (2014) theory of performativity. Butler argues how gender and body norms are constructed through repetitive acts, and TikTok creators who share unfiltered and diverse bodies are actively resisting conventional stereotypes. As Reade (2020) presented in her study, 'keeping it raw' fosters a sense of belonging and challenges traditional body ideals. Similarly in my study TikTok creators who use natural lighting and minimal editing portray the 'raw' aesthetic, creating an alternate narrative of transparency and authenticity. TikTok creators can actively resist conventional stereotypes by repeatedly showcasing unfiltered and diverse depictions of their bodies, offering audiences alternative narratives that redefine societal ideals of fitness and health.

However, the focus on physical attractiveness reinforces the societal expectation that a woman's worth coincides with her body, even in spite of these inclusive efforts. In relation to Featherstone's (2010) observation of how women's bodies are still scrutinised, aligns with the focus among aesthetic validation in TikTok. As observed in the ethnographic diary and semiotic analysis, captions like 'Every drop of sweat builds the life you want' emphasise that physical transformation equates to personal achievement. Zoonens's (1994) criticism of the media's enduring portrayal of cultural norms serves as an example of why systemic reforms are necessary. Although TikTok content can challenge stereotypes, the platform's focus on well-designed, algorithm-friendly visuals restricts the creation of more significant stories of empowerment.

This tension reflects the conflicting messages present in the fitness content on TikTok. Although creators can try to reshape expectations around body image, these initiatives take place in a cultural context that still shares appearance-based approval.

Research Question 2: How does fitness content and the creators choices contribute to idolisation of physical appearance, even while promoting new ideas of femininity?

Fitness creators on TikTok aim to redefine femininity through messaging of strength, resilience and body positivity, as shown in the prior TikTok videos. Nonetheless, the social constructions of public

expectations of women often shape their content. The creators, for instance, use transformation stories and inspirational subtitles, like the 'before and after' in Dimension One, and promote inclusivity and self-love. These visuals glorify physical changes as markers of success. Mulvey's (1975) Male Gaze theory provides a lens to critique how women's bodies remain positioned for visual consumption. Even in self-produced content, creators risk perpetuating societal standards, with women simultaneously acting as both active participants and passive subjects of objectification.

The idea of self-objectification proposed by Fredrickson and Roberts (1997) is especially relevant. The creators' emphasis on aesthetics encourages viewers to internalise approval based on appearance, even if they promote body positivity. This gives women a platform where they feel under pressure to live up to idealised standards.

Butler's (2014) concept of vulnerability further explains how preexisting norms shape these performances. Creators advocating for self-love and inclusivity may unintentionally reinforce societal pressures by aligning with the standards they aim to dismantle. Social media platforms heighten appearance anxiety, as noted by Lewallen and Behm-Morawitz (2016). This notion is arguably still consistent within TikTok through the observation of transformation narratives. Despite promoting body positivity, creator's material frequently conforms to conventional beauty standards, encouraging self-comparison and an obsession with looks.

This paradox reveals the complexities of TikTok's fitness content. While creators promote new ideas of femininity, such as celebrating diverse body types, their content choices often idolise physical appearance, maintaining the idea that a woman's physical appearance determines her value.

Research Question 3: How does TikTok's algorithmic structure influence the consumption and perception of fitness content?

TikTok's algorithm intensifies content that aligns with trends and maximises engagement, creating what Scalvini (2023) describes as 'universal sameness'. The platform prioritises videos that balance relatability and aesthetic appeal, such as natural lighting and simple environments, as observed in Dimension Three. Although videos present different narratives, their shared reliance on algorithm-friendly features reduces content diversity. This algorithm-driven homogenisation limits content diversity, perpetuating conventional norms while giving the illusion of inclusivity.

Pariser's (2011) filter bubble theory explains how TikTok's personalisation algorithm isolates users within echo chambers. Users are frequently exposed to similar narratives while interacting with particular kinds of content, which could increase social pressures related to fitness and body image. Zoonen's (1994) analysis of media as a cultural force emphasises how algorithms act as unseen influencers, guiding attitudes about health and fitness. Through the prioritisation of content that meets its algorithm's preferences, TikTok enforces these social norms by frequently linking health to aesthetic standards and physical beauty.

TikTok capitalizes on the shifting meaning of health in today's digital world, where it's no longer a straightforward concept. The platform's algorithm pushes content that ties health to physical appearance, making it harder to distinguish between genuine empowerment and content designed to perform or please. This algorithm-driven approach influences what fitness content people see and shapes their understanding of what it means to live a healthy life.

Moving Forward

After conducting and discussing my research, numerous concerns have been revealed. In order for future generations to make a difference, I suggest creators and platforms adopt strategies that prioritise inclusivity and challenge systemic pressures. By exploring TikTok, other social media platforms could also gain insight from this study.

Prior studies illustrated that exposure to body-neutral content can improve women's moods and reduce appearance-based comparisons (Seekis and Lawrence, 2023). However, my research advances their findings by addressing the role of TikTok's algorithm, which amplifies idealised standards rather than promoting holistic, inclusive narratives. Women have consistently been shown, told, and pressured to look and behave a certain way. Creators could subvert this by focusing on holistic messaging, emphasising a woman's intrinsic qualities. Videos celebrating inner strength and mental well-being instead of physical appearance will help reduce concerns about body dissatisfaction.

In alignment with Zoonen's (1994) feminist media studies critiques, realistic portrayals of women need to be shared among contemporary platforms to challenge patriarchal conventions. Authentic and inclusive content created by TikTok influencers, similar to the 'raw' aesthetic described by Reade (2020), should become more used on social media to subvert conventional norms.

As TikTok's algorithmic structure was a key focus of this study, my findings could propose TikTok implement transparent algorithms that prioritise diverse and meaningful content instead of toxic trends and messages. Moderating content is a step to ensure harmful videos are removed to enhance a healthier digital realm. By addressing algorithmic biases, as highlighted by Scalvini (2023) and Pariser (2011), this is vital for reducing the digital nature of filter bubbles and expanding the diversity of TikTok's.

Lastly, policymakers and educators could develop a program that educates viewers with media literacy skills, helping them understand how social media can be harmful. Once people are more aware, this could prevent the cycles of self-comparison and body dissatisfaction.

This chapter explored the findings from the research and discussed how fitness content can create a dual narrative between empowerment and idolisation. TikTok has changed the presentation of health, fitness and body image; whilst presenting a platform for empowerment, it also exposes the limitations of an algorithm-driven landscape. This study has expanded from prior research by focusing on TikTok and showing how the platform's algorithmic structures and creator choices complicate efforts to subvert traditional norms. By managing these concerns, TikTok has the potential to become an

inclusive space where diverse representations of health and fitness succeed., influencing a positive change in how women perceive themselves in the complicated digital realm.

Conclusion

This research explored the complex relationship between empowerment and idolisation presented in women's health and fitness content on TikTok. The findings revealed that TikTok creates a dual narrative: while many creators support inclusivity, self-love, and body neutrality, these messages are often undermined by traditional beauty standards and the self-comparison dynamics reinforced by the platform's algorithm. This study's analysis of these connections demonstrates the need of engaging with digital media critically and demonstrates how TikTok's algorithm significantly influences the framing of health and fitness narratives.

By clarifying the significant influence algorithms have on cultural narratives and gender representations, the study advances feminist media studies. Theoretically, it emphasises how important it is to study media algorithms in order to comprehend how they affect identities and social norms. Practically, the ethical consequences of algorithm-driven material must be considered in contemporary online platforms. Creators should aim to promote holistic and inclusive messages that subvert traditional beauty standards and foster genuine empowerment.

Future research should consider cross-platform comparisons and long-term studies to monitor the evolution of fitness and body image narratives. Further insights may also be obtained by examining the ways in which various demographic groups engage with and are impacted by algorithmic content. Given how quickly technology and society are changing, it is essential to keep researching how media and communication platforms like TikTok change and impact how people view identity and health. This ongoing inquiry will help create more inclusive and empowering digital environments.

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Appendix

Appendix A

Ethnographic Diary

<https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1oAeWUdtzwjLgcyNgqHzh173ViIK2zPAs?usp=sharing>

Appendix B

Link to Eleven TikTok videos analysed in the following tables.

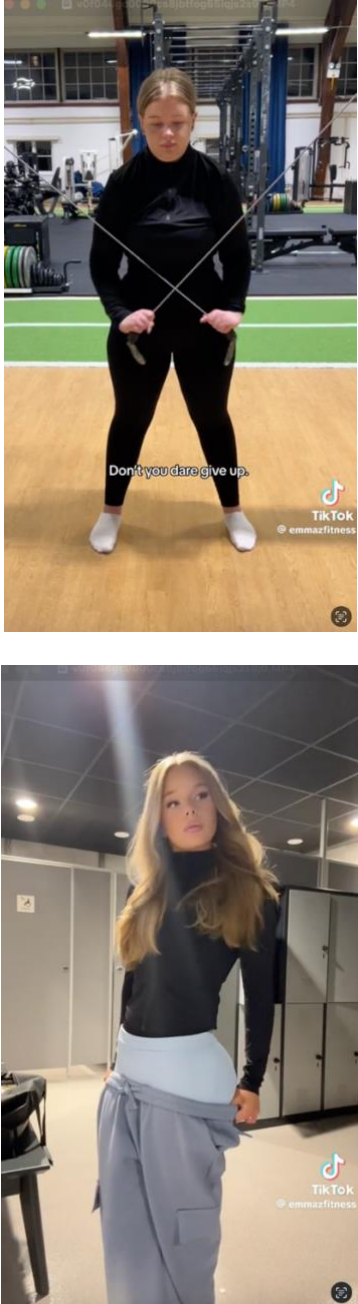
https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1-mTDLjmDdn7dKSBbUG8kWz98y6mo7jlo?usp=share_link

Table B1

TikTok One			
Semiotic Elements	Stills from the TikTok video	Denotation	Connotation
Visual (Body types, camera angles, lighting, editing techniques, clothing and accessories)		Close-up and medium shots capture the individual's entire body and exercise movement. High exposure lighting. Short clips and fast transitions between the different exercise videos aligned with the music or movement. Tight, conventional gym wear.	A female with a toned body functions as a signifier of health, discipline and desirability. Her physique could be considered aspirational but exclusionary, implying these traits are only attainable through adherence to specific fitness standards. Framing her body emphasises her as the focal point of attention and perfection. The lighting enhances the visibility of the muscle definition, glorifying the 'fit' aesthetic.
		Athletic/ Mesomorph physique. Gym environments and gym equipment.	Gym wear may serve as a dual signifier, as a practicality for fitness and as a symbol of lifestyle branding. It may suggest that achieving the 'fit' body is intertwined with consumerism, as wearing such gym wear reflects an aspirational lifestyle.

Textual (Language, music, sound, subtitles and voiceovers)		Subtitles of the TikTok sound were added to the video clips. A male voice is the narrator of the sound. High-energy music matches the tempo of movements.	Motivational captions inspire the users but could arguably reinforce the notion that fitness equates to self-worth or success. Phrases like ‘no excuses’ can imply that failure to achieve these standards reflects personal inadequacy. The music energises the video and associates physical fitness with positivity. How they edit the movements to sync with the music adds an emotional layer, enhancing motivation. The voiceovers may claim inclusivity, offering fitness motivation but focusing on an idealised outcome. This may change the narrative that only one body type represents success.
Performative (Body language, facial expressions, interactions with the camera and audience)		Each clip shows the women performing different exercises involving weights and Pilates. Body language of confidence and hard work. The woman is focused Solely on the movements.	The confident movements signify control over the body, connecting physical fitness to empowerment. This emphasises that ‘fit’ bodies are essentially superior and should be celebrated. Her facial expressions of smiles and focus express her joy and determination, suggesting how pursuing fitness can lead to happiness. This emotional appeal draws viewers into the narrative but may mask the exclusivity of the standard being promoted.

Table B2

TikTok Two			
Semiotic Elements	Stills from the TikTok video	Denotation	Connotation
Visual (Body types, camera angles, lighting, editing techniques, clothing and accessories)		Full body camera shots of the individual's entire body, capturing the exercises and poses. Short, multiple clips as the video shows the creator's transformation. Clothing choices progress into more conventional gym wear. Gym environment and equipment.	TikTok presents the creator's body transformation, emphasising how exercising has made a big impact on her appearance and confidence. Presenting a correlation between physical appearance and confidence. The individual's body is the focal point of each frame, highlighting her body transformation and journey. As her journey developed, the gym wear progressed to more tight and conventional pieces, perhaps enhancing the weight loss.

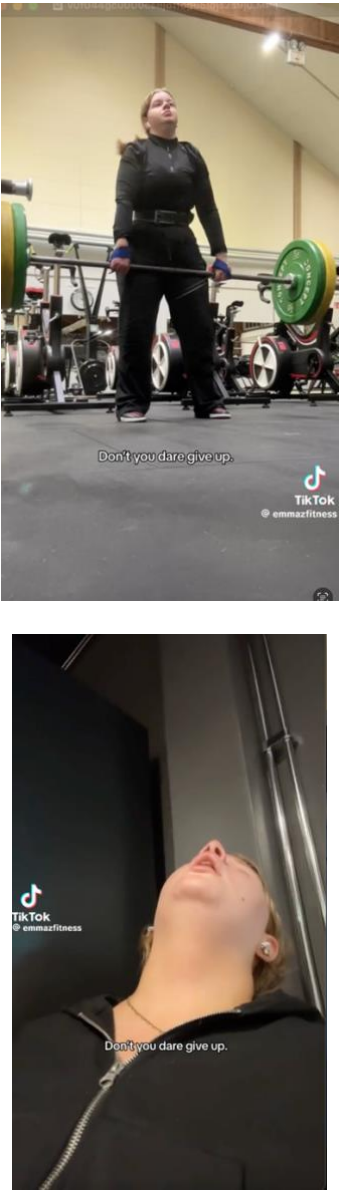
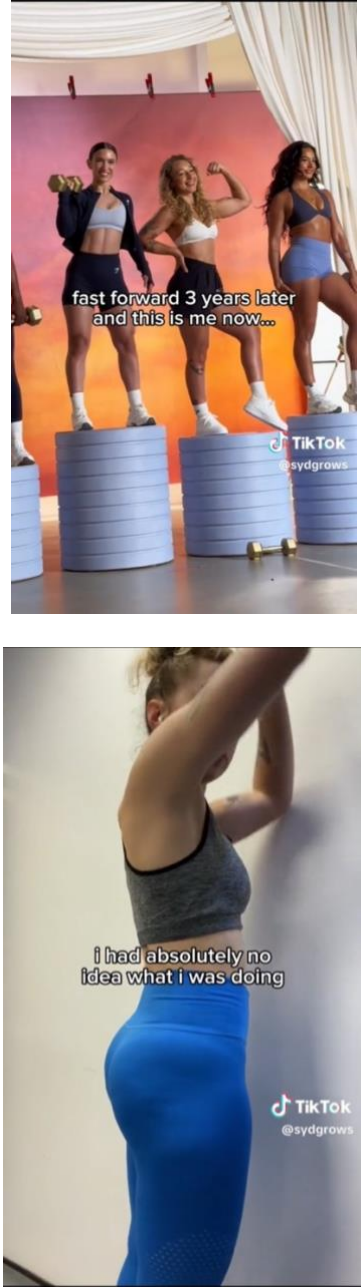
Textual (Language, music, sound, subtitles and voiceovers)		Added captions layered in the video. Emojis are used in some of the captions. High-energy music.	These captions are placed to embed the creator's message that exercising will make you look better and, therefore, feel happier. Using a direct tone of voice towards the viewers may put more pressure on them to feel the same and compare their routines and bodies. Correlation between appearance and success, ideals of how a 'fit' body means you have succeeded.
Performative (Body language, facial expressions, interactions with the camera and audience)		The clips show the creator doing varied exercises along her fitness journey. Her body language and facial expressions at the start of the video convey exhaustion and sadness.	This video embeds messages about connecting physical fitness to happiness and how a body transformation can make an individual happier, promoting 'fit' bodies as superior again. Through TikTok's narrative, the video's ending with smiles and joy suggests how happiness depends on physical appearance. As the video progresses, she includes clips of her dancing, posing and smiling, which indicates she is happier. Although she displays her fitness journey in a positive light, it can enhance viewers' understanding of a promoted standard. Viewers aspire to these idealised fit bodies.

Table B3

TikTok Three			
Semiotic Elements	Stills from the TikTok video	Denotation	Connotation
Visual (Body types, camera angles, lighting, editing techniques, clothing and accessories)		Close-up, medium and long shots are used in this TikTok, showing the creator from different angles. Range of lighting in the different clips, studio and standard lighting. Short clips were edited together to display her fitness and well-being journey. A range of clothing, primarily gym wear as well as everyday outfits. Athletic body types are shown often.	Using varied clips and angles of the creator's body emphasises the journey she is presenting and how exercise has helped her grow on the inside and her physical appearance. She is not solely focused on the gym environment, using varied clips that convey her message. However, she does include clips of her body before and after, which embed messages about focusing on physical appearance. The video primarily shows her in gym wear, enhancing her transformation of body. It suggests that happiness is linked to physical ability and appearance.

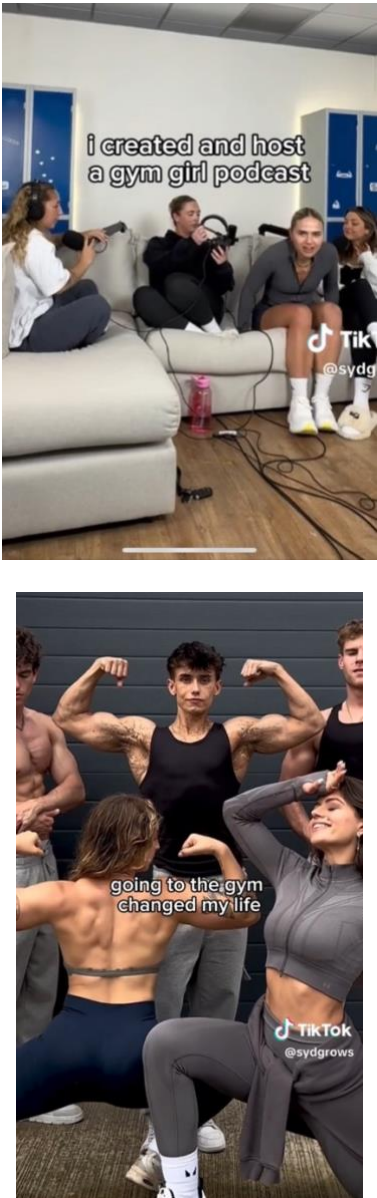
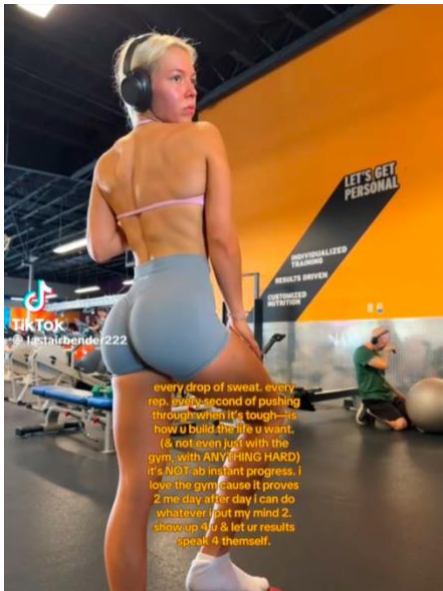
Textual (Language, music, sound, subtitles and voiceovers)		Captions were added to explain the TikTok narrative, describing her fitness and confidence journey. Focusing on finding the confidence to exercise and feel herself.	The caption story tells the clips that the key focus of her creator's confidence grew as she became more involved in the gym. The simple language used to describe her story makes the video more relatable and aspirational for viewers.
Performative (Body language, facial expressions, interactions with the camera and audience)		This video presents a range of environments and varied aspects of her life that have contributed to the positive change she is emphasising. Multiple group settings are presented. The affectionate, caring body language between the creator and others. There was lots of laughter, smiling and happiness as the video progressed. Clips of exercise movements mixed with other settings such as panel talks, podcast shows and brand events.	This TikTok involves various performative elements that all emphasise a caring and positive environment the gym can hold. Many clips present the creator with others, sharing emotions and participating in similar activities. This conveys how her progression in the gym has improved her well-being and relationships with herself and others. The TikTok increasingly showed positive facial expressions and body language as the creator shared her journey, showing viewers how surrounding yourself with like-minded people can be important. The mixed environments emphasise how her fitness journey has led her to other opportunities. Suggesting how confidence can help in dual aspects of life. Arguably, there is a focus on body appearance, underlining how confidence correlates to physical appearance.

Table B4

TikTok Four			
Semiotic Elements	Stills from the TikTok video	Denotation	Connotation
Visual (Body types, camera angles, lighting, editing techniques, clothing and accessories)		Athletic, mesomorph body type. Long camera shot that captures the individual's whole body. Conventional gym wear and equipment. Simple and minimal edits between the clips.	The messaging of this TikTok is to motivate people in the gym. Each of the camera angles captures the creator's athletic figure. Paired with the conventional gym wear and equipment in this video, these elements suggest this is a body type that can be achieved by going to the gym. The minimal clothing highlights the creator's muscles and shape, which adheres to this idealistic fit body.
Textual (Language, music, sound, subtitles and voiceovers)		The layered caption displays TikTok's message. The narrative aims to motivate people in the gym. Pop music in the background.	The caption in this video embeds a motivational narrative. It emphasises how the gym can be 'tough' and how progress is not instant. The creator emphasises how the gym makes them feel empowered and how 'results' from the gym motivate them. This message suggests that physical appearance and transformation are at the forefront of exercise, and aesthetic appeal is the aim. The upbeat music lifts the energy of the video and aligns with the motivational messaging.

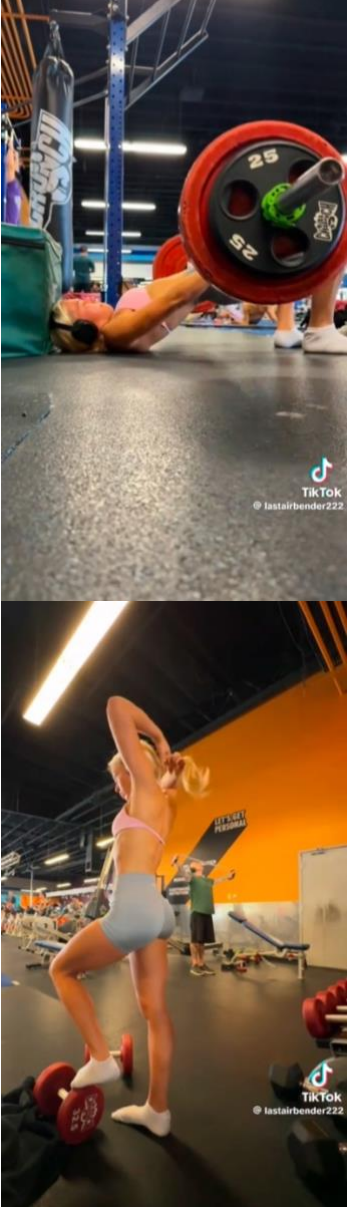
Performative (Body language, facial expressions, interactions with the camera and audience)		The individual performs a range of exercise movements and poses in front of the camera. No interaction with the camera. Focused facial expression.	The range of exercise movements and minimal interaction with the camera emphasises the creator's focus on exercising to feel accomplished. Her focus in each clip reinforces a stricter view of the gym, how she is there to exercise to look a certain way and, as a result, feel happy about her body.
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Table B5

TikTok Five			
Semiotic Elements	Stills from the TikTok video	Denotation	Connotation
Visual (Body types, camera angles, lighting, editing techniques, clothing and accessories)		Endomorph body type. Dressed in non-restrictive clothing, just her underwear. Natural lighting. Minimal editing and transitions. Varied body angles. Vlog-style edited TikTok of her 10k race. Point of view and full body camera shots.	Minimal clothing and natural lighting connote authenticity. The meaning of her running in her underwear suggests ideals of self-love. Varied camera and body angles follow her on her race, emphasising her message of raising awareness of body diversity. All the visuals enhance her messages of how all bodies deserve visibility.

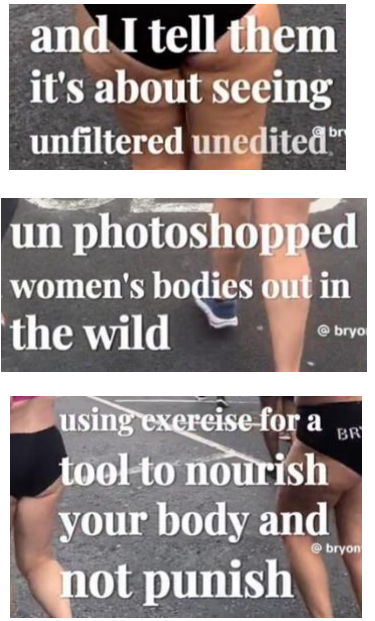
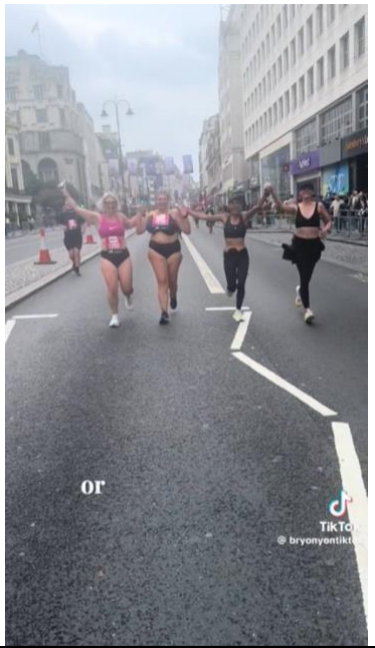
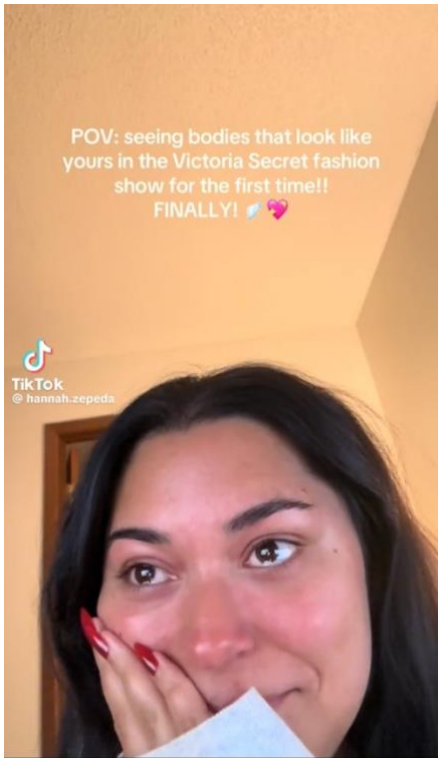
Textual (Language, music, sound, subtitles and voiceovers)		Voiceover narrated by the creator. Subtitles of the creators voiceover. Subtle uplifting music in the background.	Motivational and positive messages are shared through her voice-over and emphasised through the captions added. Key language to celebrate women's bodies. Her language avoids comparison or judgment, shifting the focus to self-acceptance rather than improvement. Reflecting ideals of that self-worth transcends physical appearance.
Performative (Body language, facial expressions, interactions with the camera and audience)		Performative body language, lots of clips showing people holding hands and shots of the woman smiling, smacking her bum. The creator interacts with the camera, breaking the fourth wall. Expressive facial expressions of joy.	The woman's casual and interactive body language with the audience enhances the intimacy and supportive space she is promoting. Reinforcing how it is a shared struggle and universal self-acceptance is the aim.

Table B6

TikTok Six			
Semiotic Elements	Stills from the TikTok video	Denotation	Connotation
Visual (Body types, camera angles, lighting, editing techniques, clothing and accessories)		Natural lighting. Casual, everyday clothing. Minimal editing, one long video shot. Individual moves to be in the whole frame.	The message of this TikTok is focusing on making all body types accepted and for women to understand how bodies change with age. This simple clip and text are impactful because they emphasise an important message with minimal elements. Casual everyday clothing and medium shots capture the creator's body to enhance the message of how she is comfortably presenting herself. Natural lighting makes her figure more visible, sharing the raw form of a body without editing.
Textual (Language, music, sound, subtitles and voiceovers)		Layered text that embeds the creators message for the video. Simple pop music in the background.	Colloquial, simple language has been used to embed an important message, and the term 'daily reminder' reinforces the idea of how women need repeated messages to subvert all the pressures they receive. The mention of the internet suggests that that is where a lot of the pressures on women's bodies stem from.

Performative (Body language, facial expressions, interactions with the camera and audience)		Direct body language towards the camera. Simple and happy body expressions are shown through dancing towards the camera. Smiley facial expressions and lip-syncing.	The individual addressing the camera and performing directly to the viewers emphasises the message because she shares her ‘normal body’ online so that others can feel empowered. Dancing and smiling elements link the idea of self-acceptance and happiness. Having inner confidence and understanding that bodies are different will make you feel happier and understood.
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Table B7

TikTok Seven			
Semiotic Elements	Stills from the TikTok video	Denotation	Connotation
Visual (Body types, camera angles, lighting, editing techniques, clothing and accessories)		Close-up camera shot of the creator's face. Natural lighting. There is no editing, just one clip. No visuals of clothing or accessories.	The TikTok is a simple video that shows a key message: the individual presents how she feels accepted in contemporary fashion shows. The infamous Victoria's Secret fashion show is known for using thin models; however, in the present day, it is seen to be more body-inclusive. The one clip captures a deep feeling of acceptance and progression in society.
Textual (Language, music, sound, subtitles and voiceovers)		A caption was added to the video describing TikTok's narrative. Displaying the creator watching the Victoria's Secret fashion show. Minimal, chill background music.	The caption expresses the raw emotion the creator is feeling. She is witnessing a positive shift in women's bodies that has had a big impact on her. 'Look like yours' reinforces the idea that people aspire to models or to what they see online. 'Finally' emphasises how people have wanted to see more body-inclusive content and recognise that there needs to be a shift in focus.

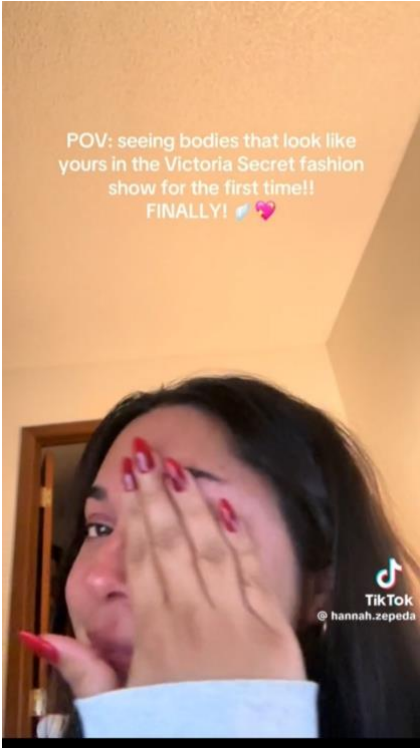
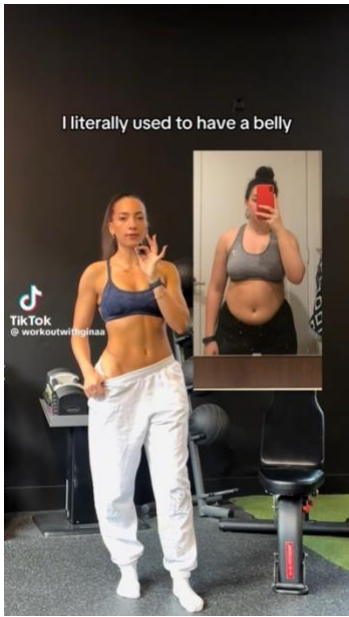
Performative (Body language, facial expressions, interactions with the camera and audience)		Facial expressions of crying with happiness. The individual is admiring the fashion show.	The creator's emotive crying because of what she is witnessing suggests the relief and joy of seeing how fashion shows progress. Her admiration implies how much of an impact self-objectification has on online spaces.
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Table B8

TikTok Eight			
Semiotic Elements	Stills from the TikTok video	Denotation	Connotation
Visual (Body types, camera angles, lighting, editing techniques, clothing and accessories)	 The top still shows a woman with blonde hair, wearing a purple long-sleeved crop top and matching leggings, posing in a room. Text overlay reads 'What I Eat In A Day' with food emojis and '*no restriction*'. The bottom still shows a close-up of a plate of food: jacket potatoes, cheese, chicken, beans, and salad. Text overlay reads 'jacket potatoes, cheese, chicken, beans + salad' with food emojis. Both stills have a TikTok watermark.	Mesomorph body type. Range of medium and close up shots. Primarily close ups of her food. Natural lighting. Simple cuts between the clips. Short clips. Gym wear and casual clothing.	The establishing shot of this TikTok is powerful because the creator is comfortably displaying her body. The natural lighting embraces her ‘ normal’ body, setting the video's narrative. The video includes simple cuts and edits to show her food throughout the day. She uses a variety of angles and shots to capture her meals, cooking and herself. This makes the video appear more casual because it allows the viewer to become a part of her daily life. The varied gym and casual clothing create more relatable messaging as they encapsulate an everyday life that doesn’t revolve around just the gym.

Textual (Language, music, sound, subtitles and voiceovers)		Captions presenting what food she is having throughout the day were added. Upbeat, pop music.	The beginning caption is impactful because the creator has emphasised ‘no restriction’; this is important because she is subverting the toxic normality of undereating and restricted diets. Her display of this is vital for creating a more supportive and safer place for women because she shows that eating should be intuitive, and that life should not revolve around diets. The uplifting pop music aligns with her messaging because it creates an atmosphere of positivity.
Performative (Body language, facial expressions, interactions with the camera and audience)		Her body language is neutral and positive throughout the day. Cheerful facial expressions. Direct eye contact with the camera whilst eating. Eating spoon falls off food in most clips.	Throughout the video, the creator includes herself cooking and eating her meals. In each clip, she is constantly smiling or dancing. This adds emphasis on creating a positive output on eating and raising awareness of how fuelling yourself is important. The establishing clip is empowering. She is smiling and exposing her stomach. She appears happy with her body and could inspire others to feel comfortable with their own. She addresses the camera with direct eye contact and expressions, which creates a shared community with her viewers. This could help people feel more connected to her content.

Table B9

TikTok Nine			
Semiotic Elements	Stills from the TikTok video	Denotation	Connotation
Visual (Body types, camera angles, lighting, editing techniques, clothing and accessories)		Mesomorph body type. High exposed lighting. She used a simple editing technique and short-medium clips of her workout routine. High-resolution video. Conventional sportswear. Gym accessories are in the foreground.	A good standard of editing and lighting contributes to the ideal of the 'flawless' body that viewers will be comparing themselves to. Heavy emphasis on physique, displaying her before and after photos.
Textual (Language, music, sound, subtitles and voiceovers)	I literally used to have a belly we're gonna do it together and we're gonna be consistent with three exercises I would say it honestly took me 3 years to like fully get rid of sustainably	Subtitles for the creators talk through her workout. She talks through her workout tutorial. There is no background music.	Her language and instructions promote ideals that her body is the idealistic one. Inclusive language as she wants to motivate users to do the same as her, to look the same.

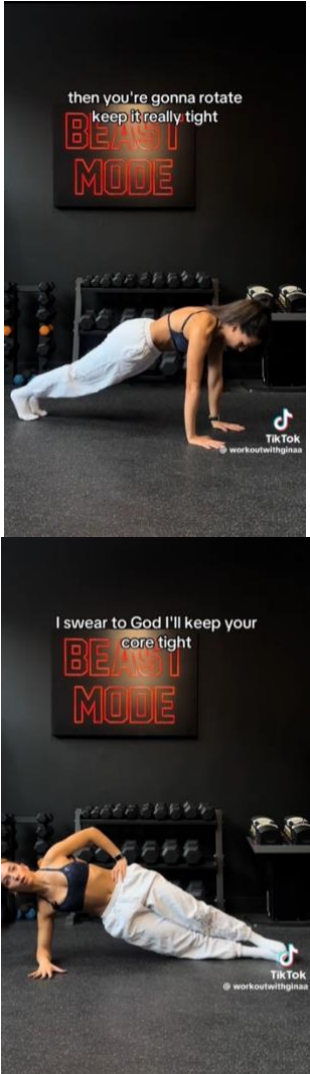
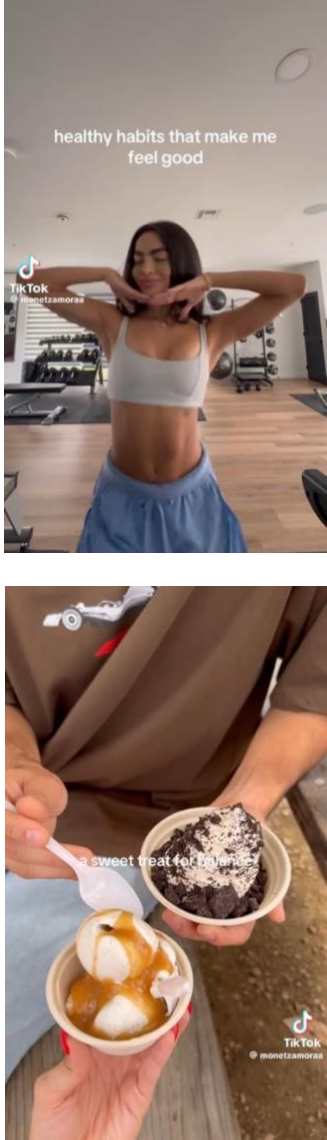
Performative (Body language, facial expressions, interactions with the camera and audience)		The creator is performing her abs routine. She is performing a range of exercises. The woman uses direct interactions with the camera to address viewers directly. Instructive engagement.	Focus on the exercise routine could mirror the algorithm's role in showing content with similar visual and narrative elements. Direct, motivational engagement increases the relatability but normalises the portrayal of an 'ideal body' as achievable through her routine.
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Table B10

TikTok Ten			
Semiotic Elements	Stills from the TikTok video	Denotation	Connotation
Visual (Body types, camera angles, lighting, editing techniques, clothing and accessories)		Medium shot camera angle. No editing, no cuts. Casual clothing and setting.	The narrative of this TikTok is to address all the pressures shared across social media and the expectations that are put on women. The camera set-up emphasises the direct mode of address the creator is communicating. Having no cuts or edits is impactful because she lists a number of pressures women face. The fast-talking and long clip reinforces this societal pressure. Her casual setting and clothing mean the focus remains on her messaging.
Textual (Language, music, sound, subtitles and voiceovers)		Added subtitles for the creator's speech. There is no background music.	The layered subtitles of her speech emphasise her words and give viewers a visual understanding. The video's lack of background music makes it more impactful because her speech is the key focus. This simple editing reinforces this in an attempt to raise awareness of how social media creates several unrealistic standards.
Performative (Body language, facial expressions, interactions with the camera and audience)		Direct mode of address to the viewers by looking at the camera. Minimal body language and movement. Straight facial expressions.	The creator's body language is minimal, but her facial expressions are serious and expressive. This adds emphasis to her speech because the sarcastic tone of voice highlights what many women experience across social media every day. The direct mode of address is empowering because it may help viewers understand how other women have recognised the concern of societal pressure on social media. This is a shared issue, and thus, addressing it through impactful speech and actions will help raise awareness.

Table B11

TikTok Eleven			
Semiotic Elements	Stills from the TikTok video	Denotation	Connotation
Visual (Body types, camera angles, lighting, editing techniques, clothing and accessories)		Athletic body type. Range of close, medium and long shots of different environments. Natural lighting. Short clips edited together. A mix of athletic clothing and everyday wear.	The video's narrative shows her showing her 'healthy' habits to feel good. Her toned physique presents an idealistic body that women may aspire to. The natural lighting makes her video appear more relatable and informal, emphasising how she lives a 'normal' life and that others should be able to do the same. A range of edited clips convey the life viewers may aspire to; she creates an image of a perfect, balanced life.
Textual (Language, music, sound, subtitles and voiceovers)		Layered captions that align with the narrative of the video. Upbeat music.	The simple captions explain her daily activities, making viewers think this is how she lives daily. This could create unobtainable standards for viewers. The uplifting pop music reinforces the attempted positive messaging she is trying to communicate.

Performative (Body language, facial expressions, interactions with the camera and audience)		The creator displays different ways of feeling her best, such as exercising, eating, and socialising. Positive facial and body expressions. Active body language, taking part in fitness classes. Different environments of her life. Such as the gym, outside hikes, the kitchen and outside eating.	Within each healthy habit, she is smiling and expressing cheerful body language, creating this narrative of how these habits can be completed daily and adhere to the pressures on viewers. Presenting daily habits makes them easy to complete each day, whereas viewers may not be able to complete the same.
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